Getting Ready to Ask What Mom Can Keep

Your family's part, in order: nine actions, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: you can hand a professional a plain, dated picture of what Mom and Dad own, whose name is on each thing, what you've been told and by whom, and which questions are still open.

Share the list. Put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Find the list of what Mom and Dad own, if you've made one, or start a rough one: the home, savings, retirement accounts, insurance and anything else of value.			
2. Pull the paper behind each thing on the list: the deed, a recent statement, the policy.			
3. Beside each thing, copy the name or names printed on its paper. Where you haven't seen the paper, write “not sure.”			
4. Mark anything owned jointly, and with whom.			
5. Find the beneficiary forms for the retirement accounts and the insurance policies, and note who is named. If you can't find one, write “not found.”			
6. If there is a trust, find the papers and note where they are. Don't try to work out what they mean.			
7. Write down what you've been told about what Mom can keep, with who said it and when. Keep what you're assuming on a separate list.			
8. Write your questions about the house, about Dad as the spouse at home, and about estate recovery. Beside each, write who it goes to: your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, a licensed financial professional, or “not sure.”			
9. Start one folder for everything from here on: copies of the papers, and a dated note of each conversation with the person's name.			

You're done when

What Mom and Dad own, whose name is on each thing, what you've been told and by whom, and your open questions are all written down, each question with a name beside it. What may be preserved, what may remain exposed and what needs to be watched later are what the review with your Medicaid planner and the right legal or financial professional is for. They aren't on this list, because they aren't the family's to settle alone.

If you get stuck

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “Not sure” is a finished line.
- If two people were told different things, write both. Sorting them out isn't on this list.
- This list is for copying down how things stand today. If someone suggests changing how something is owned, write the suggestion down as a question for an elder law attorney.
- If a letter or a notice arrives that you don't understand, ask the office that sent it what it is asking for, and put it in the folder for your Medicaid planner.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part. It doesn't determine whether Mom is eligible for Medicaid, confirm that anything is protected, or stand in for the legal and financial review it prepares you for. Rules vary by state. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

You've done your family's part: the list, the papers behind it and the questions, each with a name beside it. The planning interview asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring, along with your folder, to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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